NPR

Flock Is Catching Flak. Experts Say Other Police Surveillance Tools Are More Worrisome

Real-time crime center software is a sometimes overlooked but powerful tool allowing police to aggregate immense amounts of data, significantly expanding their surveillance reach.

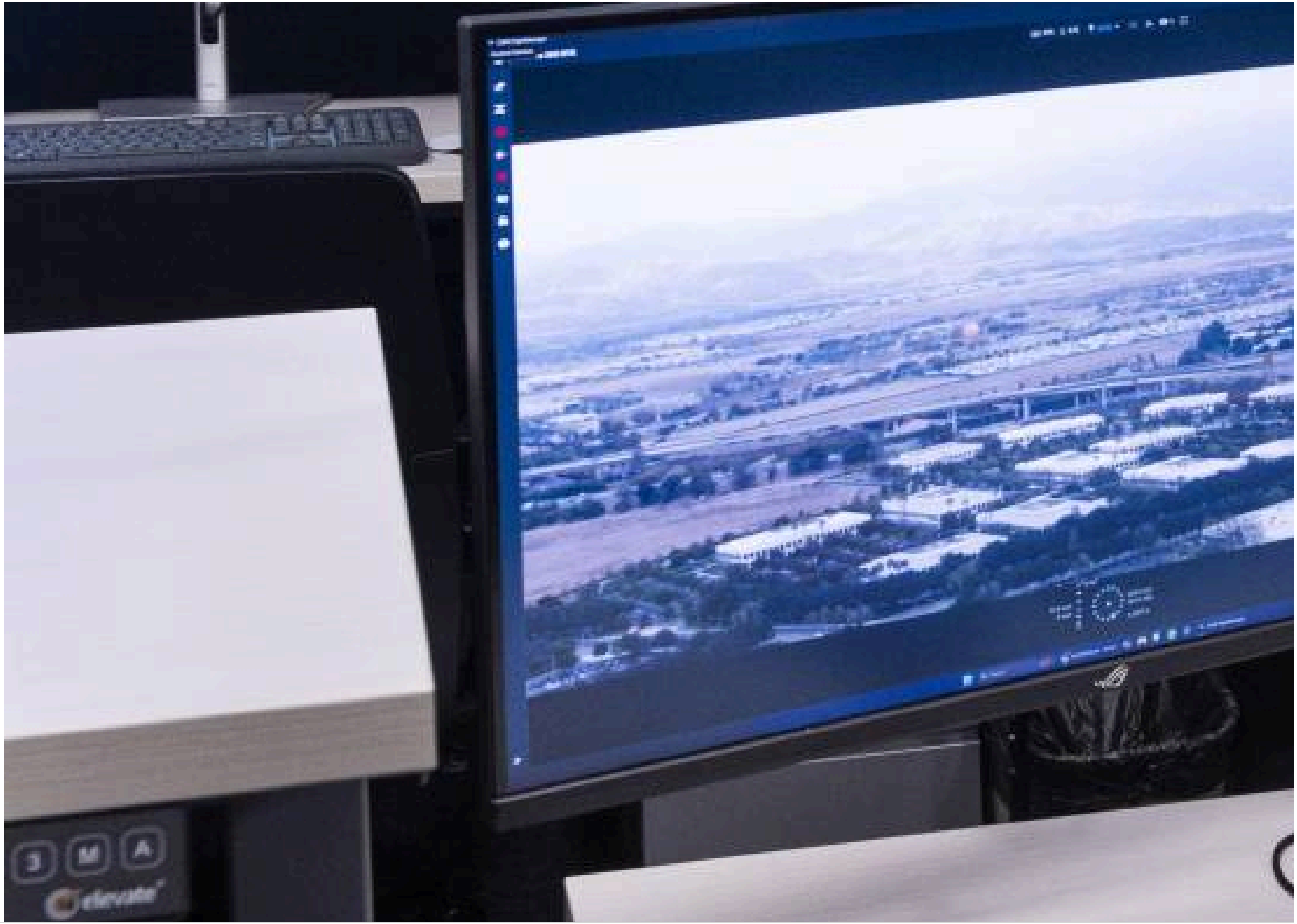
Oct 10, 2026

By **Meg Anderson, NPR**

LISTEN

Make us preferred on Google


Monitoring
1st Floor Lobby 17...
Live





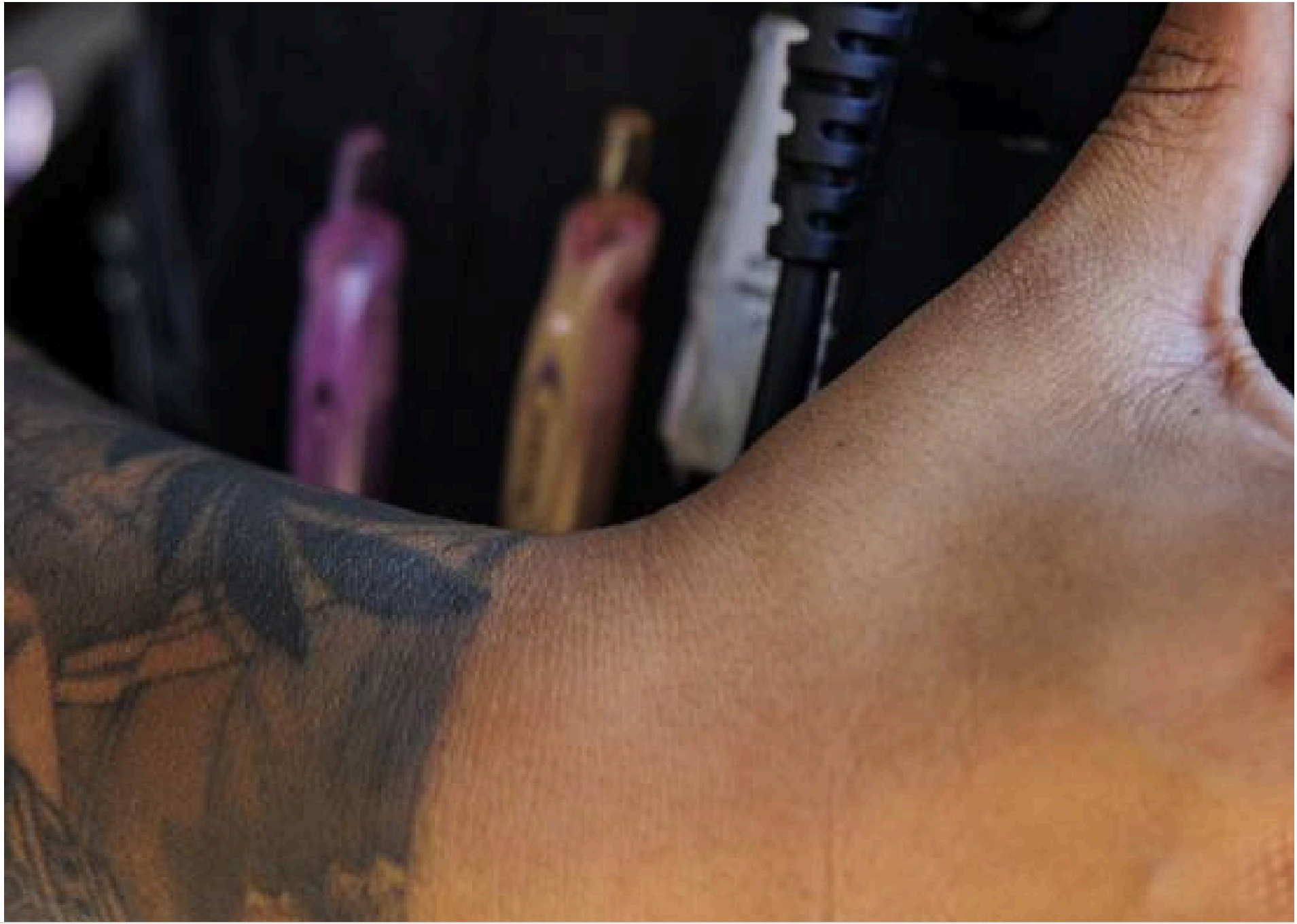
A police officer monitors video surveillance in the real-time crime center at the Irvine Police Department in California in 2024. Real-time crime center software is a sometimes overlooked but powerful tool allowing police to aggregate immense amounts of data, significantl

Police officers in cities across the United States are quick to extol the virtues of real-time crime centers as a game changer that helps them find missing children, monitor large events from the skies and scope ou

Hundreds of police departments have one of these central hubs, which have existed for years. But many are now being powered with AI software, such as Fusus, from the public-safety technology giant Axon.

Fusus, by Axon's own description, is a "rapidly deployable real-time crime center in the cloud." It functions like the brain of a crime center, synthesizing the data it pulls in and allowing police command centers


MOTOROLA





An East Palo Alto Police officer's Axon body camera in East Palo Alto on Sept. 23, 2024. *(Martin do Nascimento/KQED)*

Flock cameras, the automated license plate readers, have faced intense backlash in recent months amid stories of abuse. Yet privacy experts say they're just the tip of the iceberg when it comes to police surveill

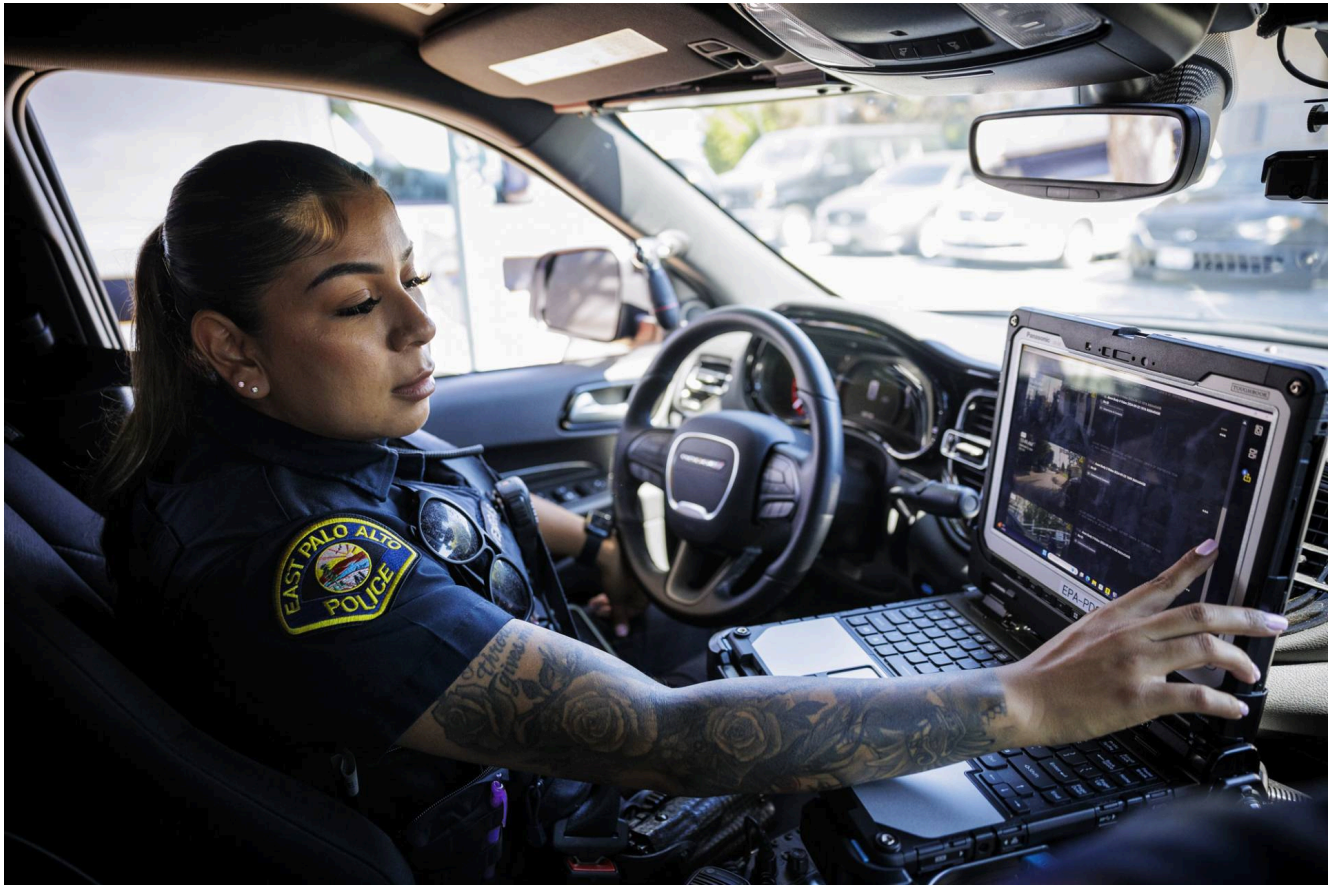
"I have been watching the debate about Flock with a little bit of puzzlement," says Andrew Guthrie Ferguson, a law professor at George Washington University. "Because real-time crime centers have not just A

How AI-powered software fuels real-time crime centers

Tools like Axon Fusus, which is a leader in this type of software, also pull in footage and data from police body cameras, law enforcement dashcams, 911 dispatch, gunshot detectors and surveillance cameras, i

Its use is growing fast. In 2024, the technology news site 404 Media reported that just over 100 law enforcement agencies had deployed Fusus, which was then its own company and was acquired by Axon that

RELATED ARTICLE



How Artificial Intelligence Is Changing The Reports Polic

Police officers in departments that use Fusus told NPR that the tool serves as a time-saver and a force multiplier for their agencies.

“We could put analysts in a room and have them access 40 different systems,” says Benjamin Weir, a captain with the Oklahoma City Police Department. “But that slows them down. So the biggest leveraging f

Quincy Whitner, a lieutenant with the Greenville County Sheriff’s Office in South Carolina, says Fusus helped his department find a man who shot a police officer and fled the scene, by combining city surveill

“Instead of having to go to a million different systems, a million different places to find answers, we can get it in one platform in one place somewhat instantaneously,” says Whitner.

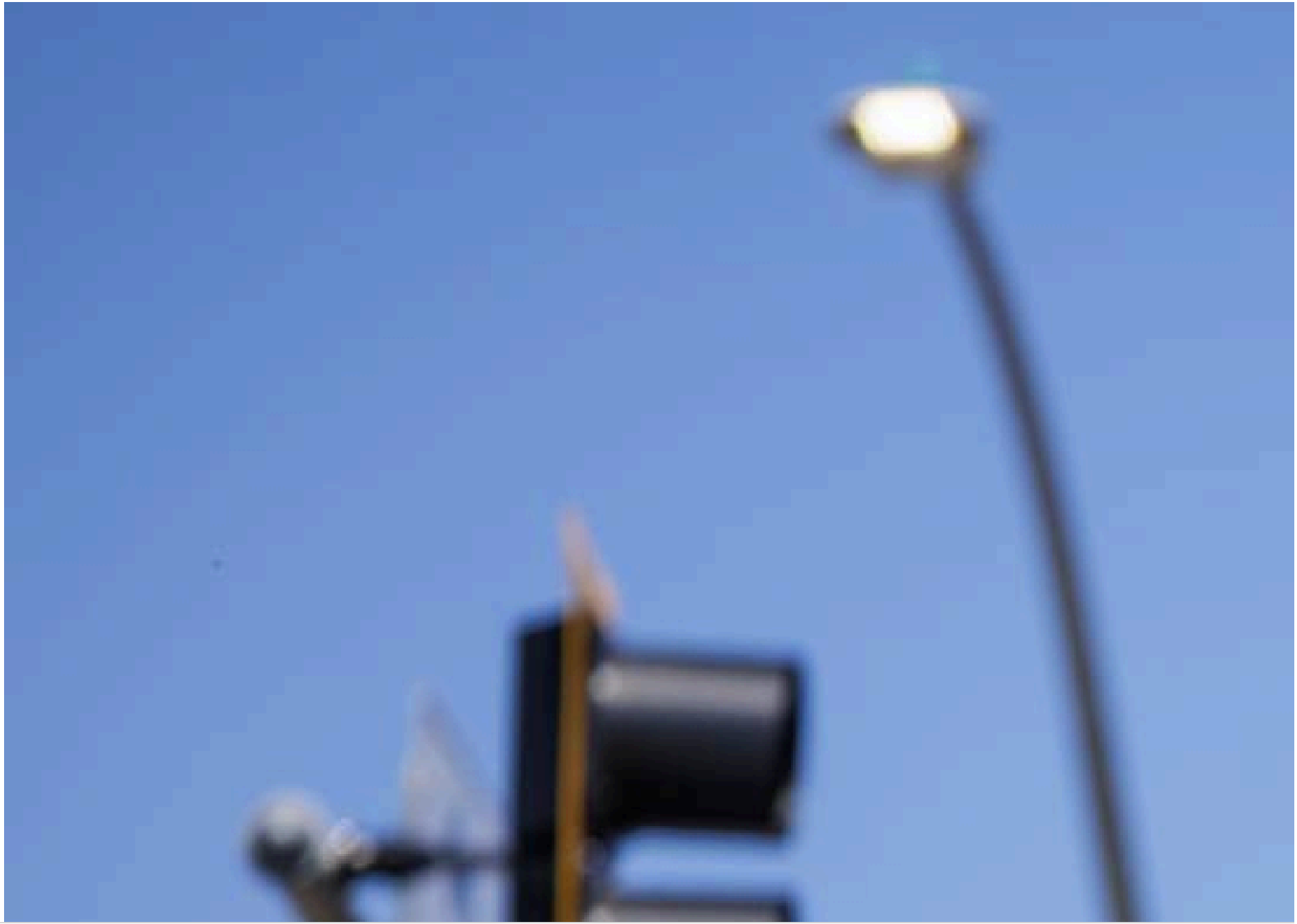
Privacy concerns when surveillance is easy

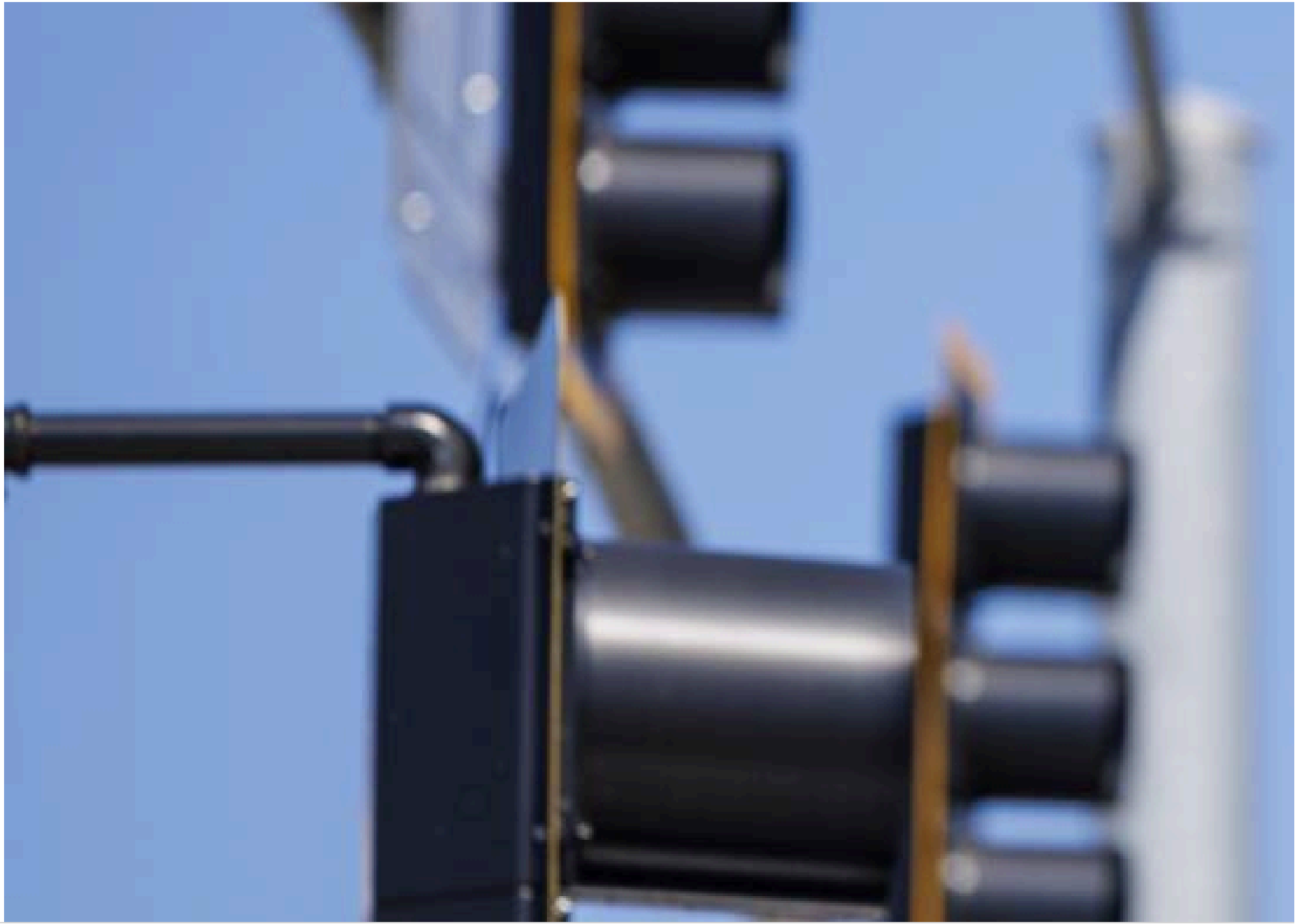
But that push-of-a-button mentality is exactly what makes privacy experts nervous.

Rachel Levinson-Waldman, director of the Liberty and National Security Program at New York University's Brennan Center for Justice, says even a few decades ago, there were more hurdles to overcome wher

"In addition to all of the things that you would want in place requiring some kind of criminal predicate to launch it, there is just this kind of organic friction that imposes some constraints," she says. "As that fri

Police told NPR that they understand those concerns but that the good — the potential for stopping and solving crime — outweighs the bad — the potential for misuse and mass surveillance.







A Flock camera monitors the intersection at McKee Road and North White Road in San José on April 2, 2026. *(Martin do Nascimento/KQED)*

“I understand people’s concerns, but if you’re not up to no good, we’re not looking at you. We are looking at people who are committing crimes,” says Michelle Iezzi, deputy director of the Operational Intellige

Axon did not respond to multiple requests for comment. But CEO Rick Smith said on the latest earnings call that the company strongly values privacy: “We just have to be thoughtful and understand those conc

But there is broad potential for abuse when a police department is always watching, privacy experts say; surveillance technology can sweep up innocent people by mistake, and it can enable targeting.

“What happens if there is a government that wants to silence a particular group or even a particular person? And you just built the architecture of surveillance that makes that super-easy,” says Ferguson, the Ge

Courts are moving slowly in deciding when or if this kind of surveillance crosses a constitutional line. In the meantime, Ferguson says, lawmakers could act by limiting how long data is stored, for instance, ma

He says those conversations should be happening before a tool ever is used.

Copyright © 2026 NPR

STEVE INSKEEP, HOST:

Protesters in many cities have focused on Flock cameras, which use AI to gather information on passing cars. Privacy experts are pointing out another surveillance tool – technology and police command centers

MEG ANDERSON, BYLINE: Police officers in cities across the country will tell you their real-time crime center is a game changer. They'll tell you how it helps them find missing children, monitor big events

(SOUNDBITE OF ARCHIVED RECORDING) UNIDENTIFIED PERSON: Welcome to Axon Fusus, your rapidly deployable real-time crime center in the cloud.

ANDERSON: Software like Fusus from the public safety tech company Axon functions like a brain. It synthesizes the data it pulls in, creating a one-stop shop for police surveillance.

(SOUNDBITE OF ARCHIVED RECORDING) UNIDENTIFIED PERSON: Now video and data feeds from a variety of sources and apps can be viewed together in a single pane of glass.

ANDERSON: By now, you've probably heard a lot about automated license plate readers like Flock. But researchers who study police technology told NPR real-time crime centers are much more extensive. Th
surveillance footage with license plate data.

QUINCY WHITNER: It's a time and a force multiplier for us. Instead of having to go to a million different systems, a million different places to find answers, we can get it in one platform and one place somew

ANDERSON: But that push-of-a-button mentality is exactly what makes privacy experts nervous. Rachel Levinson-Waldman studies these tools at New York University's Brennan Center for Justice. She says e

RACHEL LEVINSON-WALDMAN: If an officer or a police department wanted to follow somebody, wanted to do a stakeout, wanted to launch an investigation, part of the friction is the resources that go into

ANDERSON: Like staffing and time. There needed to be a good reason to go to all that effort. Now, she says, it is just easier to justify watching people.

LEVINSON-WALDMAN: So in some ways, going from the, we have this individualized reason to suspect wrongdoing, to, well, we just have a wealth of data – let's look in there and maybe see if we can find s

ANDERSON: Police told NPR they understand those concerns but that the good outweighs the bad. Michelle Iezzi manages the real-time crime center at the Montgomery County Police Department in Marylan

MICHELLE IEZZI: I understand people's concerns. But if you're not up to no good, we're not looking at you (laughter). We are looking at people who are committing crimes.

ANDERSON: Axon did not respond to multiple requests for comment. But CEO Rick Smith said in the company’s latest earnings call that they strongly value privacy.

(SOUNDBITE OF ARCHIVED RECORDING)

RICK SMITH: We just have to be thoughtful and understand those concerns and say, look, this is a tool to amplify human ability not to replace human judgment.

ANDERSON: But, like we’ve seen with Flock cameras, there is potential for abuse when a police department is always watching. Privacy experts say tech can get it wrong. People can get swept up by mistake

(SOUNDBITE OF SONG, “WATCHING THE DETECTIVES”) ELVIS COSTELLO: (Singing) Just like watching the detectives. Don’t get cute.

CAL

An
One

Download the KQED app:



Copyright © 2026 KQED Inc. All Rights Reserved.

word word word